AMARLLİYS

October/25

Inside:Expert care tips,variety highlights,and propagation methods.

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Amaryllis:The Winter Bloom

‘White Amadeus,’ a double varietal developed by Dutch breeder N.L. van Geest, puts on a performance with large blossoms, numerous petals, and hints of green at its center.

Photo courtesy of N.L. Van Geest

As we bundle up to face the cold days of winter, we often find ourselves longing for signs of spring—especially the first flowers to emerge. While it’s impossible to speed up Mother Nature’s course, there is one bloom you can enjoy indoors as you anticipate warmer weather. Quintessentially fascinating yet within anyone’s reach, amaryllis start to blossom just when you crave flowers most. In a blink (okay, more like eight weeks), the plants will go from boring bulbs to big, beautiful blooms. What could be a better antidote to the winter blues?

The Story of Amaryllis

The splendor of amaryllis magnifies when cut and arranged en masse, as Dallas stylist and floral designer Jimmie Henslee does with 'Rilona' stems in a brass urn.

Technically known as hippeastrum, the amaryllis is native to South America. Its name (which means "to sparkle" in Greek) was derived from a similar plant from South Africa known as Amaryllis belladonna.

By 1799, English watchmaker and amateur horticulturist Arthur Johnson began interbreeding these flower-power bulbs to create more magic.

Photo by David Hillegas

Ever since, the effort has been ongoing to improve on perfection and build a better amaryllis that features massive blossoms, vary- ing shades from sparkling white to deepest blood red, picotee and streaked forms, and an assortment of petal shapes.

New introductions are forever on the horizon, but many oldies remain mainstream such as the pink bloomer streaked with white flairs known as ‘Apple Blossom’ and the sparkling ‘Red Lion.’ Breeders such as the van Geest family in the Netherlands have.

Naturel Beauty-Before the Bloom

Photo by Simona Flamigni

Before planting, amaryllis bulbs resemble ornaments crafted by nature.

While it only takes one pot to create a festive display (above), the splendor of amaryllis magnifies when cut and arranged en masse, as Dallas stylist and floral designer Jimmie Henslee does with ‘Rilona’ stems in a brass urn.

Photo by David Hillegas

While it only takes one pot to create a festive display (above), the splendor of amaryllis magnifies when cut and arranged en masse, as Dallas stylist and floral designer Jimmie Henslee does with ‘Rilona’ stems in a brass urn.

The Art of Colour and From

Photo by Brittany Ambridge

To add height to a garland on her living room mantel, Tina Yaraghi of The Enchanted Home tucks potted amaryllis within the greenery and pinecones.

Beyond striving for extra-large blooms (sometimes called Jumbo), growers also desire a sturdy stalk to support the display, as well as thick petal substance. But what they aspire to the most is exquisite color.

The velvety reds might feature the depth of darkened, almost burgundy overtones in their center while striping and streaks give the blossom nuance. Picotee edging adds panache, and throat hues bring depth.

According to Gerard, white and red reign; however, his family's nursery also promotes pink and lemon varieties. Gerard explains that because doubles have become popular, they are focusing on varying petal configurations from neatly tucked layering to less formal, pointed, many-petaled introductions.

Amaryllis:From Bulb to Bloom

'White Amadeus,' a double varietal developed by Dutch breeder N.L. van Geest, puts on a performance with large blossoms, numerous petals, and hints of green at its center.

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Photo courtesy of N.L. Van Geest

Photo by Gilberto Freihoff

Gilberto Freihoff of Dogwood & Fir in San Diego appreciates Cybister varieties for their sculptural, spider-like petals. “Amaryllis teach me patience as they take their time to process and bloom, but once they do, they’re longlasting and don’t hesitate to show off their beauty,” he says.

In a midwinter arrangement, nothing achieves the va-va-voom drama quite like an amaryllis as a focal flower. Clustered together, they create an articulate dialogue. Coupled with foliage or other players, the blooms send rhythm through an arrangement.

Design&Varieties

Double Delicious

Rebecca

Rilona

Prepare to Plant

The traditional mode is to grow a bulb in a potting medium—any standard potting soil does the trick. Half to a third of the bulb should be exposed above the soil. Amaryllis prefer dry conditions prior to blooming, so a fairly snug container is a good choice. Amaryllis breeder Gerard van Geest says that starting an amaryllis in pebbles, seashells, or beach glass without soil is also a viable option.

"The energy is already in the bulb," he adds. Waxed bulbs that need no further planting medium are a relatively new fixture on the market. They perform without roots but cannot easily be coaxed to repeat the display in subsequent years, making them one-time wonders.

Care&Repeat

'Apple Blossom'-Photo courtesy of White Flower Farm

Water With Care

"Too much water in the beginning will lead to a long stem, which tends to topple unless strongly staked," Gerard cautions. "When the flowers are almost open, the amaryllis needs water."

Bloom and Repeat

After the dramatic display is finished (including multiple stems that often follow the initial blooms), give amaryllis their best shot at a repeat performance. Place them in a sunny spot and provide water and fertilizer throughout the summer

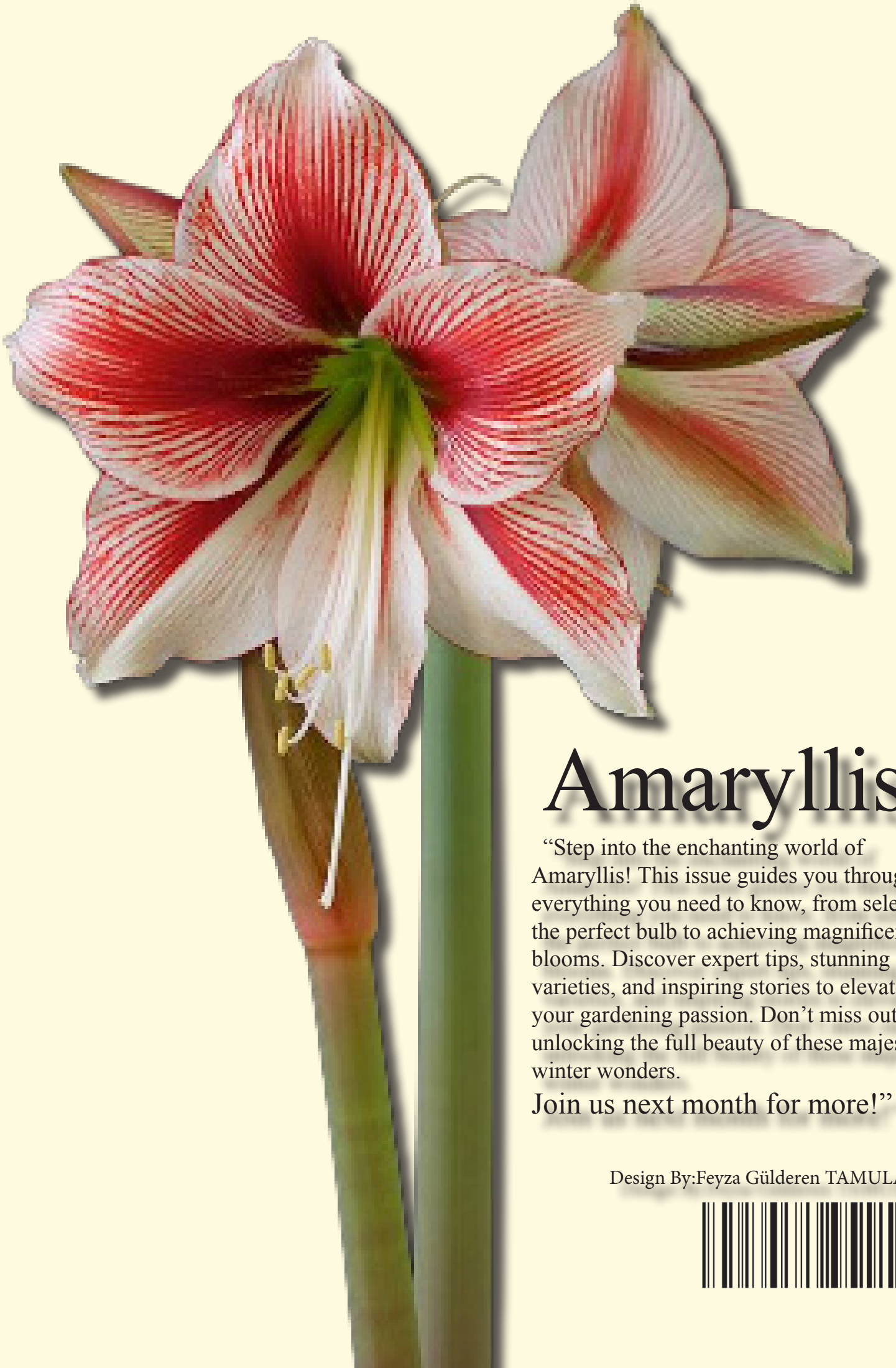
while the bulbs gather energy for next year. Cut back the foliage in September and let the bulb rest by withholding water until November. Thwen give them light and water to spark another year of glory for all to enjoy.

Red Lion

Diamond Group Picotee'

A Final Note

Amaryllis plants are poisonous to people and pets, so be sure to keep them safely out of reach of potential nibblers.



Amaryllis

"Step into the enchanting world of Amaryllis! This issue guides you through everything you need to know, from selecting the perfect bulb to achieving magnificent blooms. Discover expert tips, stunning varieties, and inspiring stories to elevate your gardening passion. Don't miss out on unlocking the full beauty of these majestic winter wonders.

Join us next month for more!"

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